

The Daemons Within

Still using Yahoo! and MSN? Here are some super-simple chat solutions for both office and home

Instant messaging (IM) isn't just used for chatting with friends anymore. It's pretty much a standard intra-office communication tool as well. Why walk a few feet to tell a colleague something, when you can quickly type out a message and hit [Enter], right?

IM depends entirely on the Internet, and this is where the problem begins. What about offices where employees don't have Net access, where dial-up access is used, or where all IM ports are blocked by a terrifying systems administrator?

Here's a simple solution—get yourself a Linux box, install a chat daemon, inform your colleagues and get a big pat on the back from your boss—you've just saved the company some money on otherwise wasted bandwidth.

JABBER

Beware the Jabberwock, my son!

The jaws that bite, the claws that catch!

Unlike Lewis Carroll's proclamation, Jabber is really just a neat way to start your own local chat server. Jabber runs happily on an underpowered rig, provided there's enough network bandwidth.

To get the Jabber server up, you can either choose one of its many open and closed source implementations or, head to Jabber.org and download the JabberD Quickstart server (<http://jabberd.jabberstudio.org/quickstart/>). This contains pre-compiled binaries and a neat setup script.

Create a separate user account within a new group, in order to run Jabber. Though not compulsory, this makes sense from a security point of view. Also, install Jabber in a directory with the required permissions.

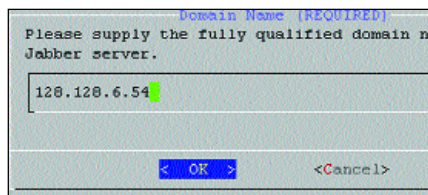
Log in as superuser and run the `'groupadd jabber'` command, followed by `'mkdir /usr/local/jabber'` to create a directory where you can install and run Jabber. Now, run `'useradd -d /usr/local/jabber jabber -g jabber'` to create the user 'jabber', with the home directory at `/usr/local/jabber` and within the group 'jabber'. After all this jabbering, use `'chown jabber:jabber /usr/local/jabber'` to get jabber the permissions on the home directory. Copy the compressed Quickstart installer into this directory.

Start jabbering

Untar the Quickstart daemon from the `/usr/local/jabber` directory while logged in as the user 'jabber'. You don't need to log in as root while untarring, setting up or running JabberD. Change to the directory containing the extracted JabberD and run the setup script by typing `./setup.sh`

This opens up the General Configuration menu. Here, select 'Gen' and supply a fully-qualified domain name for your jabber server. This can either be a name such as **gothic.sytes.net** that maps to the jabber server machine's IP, or the IP address of the Linux box, if you intend to make this sit on a LAN and behind a firewall.

The next, step asks for the name of the server. Press OK to skip. The third screen



Setting the domain name for your Jabber server is simple; just type in the computer's IP

asks for a server description. At the fourth, you are asked for a URL that users can view. Again, these are optional.

Following this, the setup script prompts you for a JabberD server administrator name. Use the formerly created jabber user account, and enter in the server administrator password. Remember, this is not the root password; it's just the JabberD admin password.

Choose 'Yes' when asked to enable PID-file support. This completes the General

No IP? No problem!

All right, you have the bandwidth, and the Linux box in place, but you don't have a static IP address, or a domain that you'd like to tag that IP to. Well, this is how you can work around the annoyance of dynamic IP allocation.

Look up www.no-ip.com—a free service that lets you have a sub-domain under the various domains they own. Sign up, and get your box a name as cool as **gothic.sytes.net**. Download their tiny application program to get this domain to reflect your changing IP address.

It comes in flavours for Linux, Unix, Windows and Macintosh. Untar the file, run `'make'` and `'make install'`. Enter the e-mail address and passwords you set while registering, and run it in the background. The application automatically gets the current IP address and sends the same to no-ip.com. They update this in the DNS records on the Internet, and voila, **gothic.sytes.net** will redirect traffic to your box.



“If you can install the OS, you can install and run an IRCd”

JACKSON LOW (a.k.a. metalrock), MusIRCd daemon developer and final year Computer Engineering student at California State Polytechnic University, Pomona, on the minimum system requirements to run MusIRCd

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